

The Existential Autopsy of CX

Why the Customer Experience Function Exists — and Why It's Broken by Design

The Real Question

What is CX actually for?

CX conversations almost always start with “how do we improve it?”

But the more fundamental question is *why this function exists at all*.

If every function in a business already serves customers, why do we need a separate one to remind them?

The Global View: What Actually Drives Business Outcomes?

Let's strip it down to the core forces that determine whether a business survives and thrives:

- 1. Market Demand** - Does anyone want what you're selling? Is the need real, growing, or dying?
 - 2. Competitive Position** - Can you deliver better value (quality/price/convenience) than alternatives?
 - 3. Operational Capability** - Can you actually deliver what you promise, at scale, profitably?
 - 4. Strategic Adaptation** - Can you sense shifts (technology, behavior, competition) and evolve before irrelevance?
 - 5. Capital Efficiency** - Can you generate returns that justify continued investment?
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Now: Where Does "Customer Experience" Fit?

Here's the uncomfortable truth you're circling:

CX isn't a *driver* of these forces - it's a *symptom* or *signal* of them.

Let me unpack:

- **If demand is dying** (Blockbuster, Kodak), improving "customer experience" doesn't create demand for an obsolete category
 - **If competitive position erodes** (Yahoo vs Google), being "easier to use" doesn't overcome a 10x inferior product
 - **If operations are broken** (supply chain collapse, quality failures), measuring satisfaction doesn't fix the system
 - **If strategy is wrong** (Nokia betting on hardware keyboards), delighting customers with the wrong thing accelerates failure
 - **If unit economics don't work** (WeWork, many DTC brands), happy customers still lead to bankruptcy
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The Brutal Realization

CX has been invented as a *downstream monitoring function* for forces it doesn't control.

It's like creating a "Department of Thermometer Reading" and then wondering why it doesn't control temperature.

The Pattern:

1. Business makes strategic decisions (product, pricing, positioning, operations)
2. Customers react to those decisions
3. CX measures those reactions
4. CX reports findings
5. Business may or may not act on them
6. CX has no authority to change the underlying drivers

This is why CX feels like commentary, not infrastructure.

Because it *is* commentary—by design.

So What IS CX?

Let me attempt a ruthless definition:

Customer Experience is the organizational function that monitors and reports on how customers perceive and respond to the aggregate output of all other business decisions.

In other words:

- Product builds things
- Marketing positions things
- Sales sells things
- Operations delivers things
- Finance prices things
- Technology enables things

CX measures how customers *feel* about all of that.

The Existential Questions This Raises

Question 1: Is CX a Real Function or an Audit Function?

If CX doesn't *make* the decisions that drive experience, is it actually a business function—or is it an **internal audit of other functions' output**?

Compare:

- **Finance** makes capital allocation decisions → real function
- **Internal Audit** monitors compliance → oversight function

Is CX more like the latter?

Question 2: Why Does CX Need a "Seat at the Table"?

If CX's job is to report what customers think about decisions made elsewhere, why does it need executive authority?

The typical argument: "We need a seat at the table so we can advocate for the customer!"

The counter: Every function should advocate for customers. Product should build what customers need. Operations should deliver reliably. Pricing should be fair.

Why does advocating for customers require a separate function?

Unless...

Question 3: Is CX Admitting Other Functions Don't Care About Customers?

If we need a "Chief Customer Officer" to ensure customer-centricity, are we implicitly saying:

- The Chief Product Officer doesn't care about customers?
- The Chief Operating Officer doesn't care about customers?
- The Chief Marketing Officer doesn't care about customers?

If they DO care about customers, what is CX adding beyond redundancy?

If they DON'T care about customers, why do we hire executives who don't care about customers?

The Paradox

Here's where I think you're going:

CX exists because it *shouldn't* need to exist.

It's a **corrective function** created when businesses realize:

- Product teams optimize for features, not outcomes
- Operations teams optimize for cost, not experience
- Sales teams optimize for deals, not relationships
- Marketing teams optimize for acquisition, not retention

CX emerges as the function that says: *"Hey, someone should be looking at this from the customer's actual perspective."*

But this creates an absurd situation:

CX becomes responsible for outcomes it cannot control, measuring variables determined by functions that don't report to it.

The Core Critique

Let me sharpen your challenge:

CX is a symptom of organizational dysfunction, not a solution to it.

A truly customer-centric organization wouldn't need a CX function because:

- Product would build based on customer jobs-to-be-done
- Operations would design for customer ease
- Pricing would reflect customer-perceived value
- Marketing would communicate with customer clarity
- Technology would enable customer convenience

The existence of CX as a separate function is proof that these functions aren't doing their jobs customer-centrally.

So we create CX to "monitor" them—but give it no authority to *change* them.

What This Means

If this critique holds, then:

CX isn't infrastructure - it's organizational theater.

It's the function businesses create to *look* customer-centric without actually *being* customer-centric.

It's easier to:

- Hire a Chief Customer Officer
- Create a CX dashboard
- Run NPS surveys
- Hold "customer-centric" workshops

Than to:

- Actually rebuild product development around customer problems
 - Actually redesign operations for customer ease
 - Actually price based on customer value
 - Actually hold executives accountable for customer outcomes
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Let's Go Deeper: The Foundational Inquiry

I'm going to push on the core questions until we hit bedrock. Stop me when I'm off track.

Foundation Question 1: What Problem Does a Business Actually Have?

Let's strip away all abstraction:

A business exists to **create value for customers profitably and sustainably**.

That requires:

- **Knowing what customers value** (demand intelligence)
- **Delivering that value reliably** (operational capability)
- **Doing so better than alternatives** (competitive advantage)
- **Adapting when value shifts** (strategic evolution)
- **Capturing enough value to sustain operations** (unit economics)

Every business problem is some failure in one of these five.

Foundation Question 2: Where Does "Customer Experience" Touch These?

Let's map it:

Business Requirement	Who Owns It Today?	Does CX Own It?
Knowing what customers value	Product Management, Market Research	CX "informs" it
Delivering that value reliably	Operations, Engineering, Supply Chain	CX "monitors" it
Doing so better than alternatives	Strategy, Product, Marketing	CX "benchmarks" it
Adapting when value shifts	Strategy, Innovation, R&D	CX "signals" it
Capturing enough value	Finance, Pricing, Sales	CX "measures sentiment" around it

Notice the pattern:

CX doesn't *own* any of these. It **observes, measures, reports, informs, signals**.

Foundation Question 3: Is Observation a Legitimate Function?

Here's where it gets interesting.

Observation IS legitimate—if it's the input to a closed-loop system.

Examples of legitimate observation functions:

- **Quality Control** → observes defects → triggers corrective action → validates outcome
- **Financial Audit** → observes compliance gaps → triggers remediation → validates closure
- **Security Operations** → observes threats → triggers response → validates mitigation

What makes these legitimate?

1. **Clear trigger authority** → When they detect something, *action is mandated*
 2. **Closed-loop verification** → They verify that action *actually resolved* the issue
 3. **Accountability** → Someone is responsible for *acting* on their findings
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Foundation Question 4: Does CX Operate as a Closed-Loop System?

Let's test current CX against those criteria:

Criterion	Quality Control	Financial Audit	Current CX
Clear trigger authority	✓ Defect found → production stops	✓ Violation found → remediation required	✗ Issue found → "we should discuss this"
Closed-loop verification	✓ Re-test until defect resolved	✓ Re-audit until compliant	✗ Maybe re-survey later?
Accountability	✓ Plant manager accountable for resolution	✓ CFO accountable for compliance	✗ CX "advocates" but doesn't enforce

Current CX is an open-loop system.

It observes → reports → hopes someone acts → rarely verifies → doesn't enforce.

Foundation Question 5: Why Is CX Open-Loop?

Two possibilities:

Possibility A: CX Measures Things No One Controls

If "customer satisfaction" is the *emergent output* of Product + Operations + Marketing + Sales + Pricing + Technology, then **no single function can "fix" it.**

CX reports on a *systemic outcome* that requires *cross-functional orchestration* to change.

Problem: CX has no authority to orchestrate cross-functionally.

Possibility B: The Things CX Measures Aren't Actually Prioritized

If businesses say they care about customer experience but *act* based on:

- Quarterly revenue targets
- Cost reduction mandates
- Competitive feature parity
- Regulatory compliance

Then CX findings are **aspirational inputs, not operational imperatives.**

Problem: CX is measuring something the organization values *rhetorically* but not *operationally*.

Foundation Question 6: So What IS the Legitimate Job-to-Be-Done?

Let me attempt a synthesis:

The legitimate JTBD might be:

"Close the loop between customer perception and enterprise action—such that misalignments between what we think we deliver and what customers actually experience are systematically detected, prioritized, resolved, and verified."

If that's the JTBD, then CX is legitimate **IF AND ONLY IF** it can:

1. **Detect misalignment** (perception $\neq$ intent)
2. **Trigger resolution** (someone must act)
3. **Verify closure** (did it actually change?)
4. **Enforce accountability** (who owns the outcome?)

Current CX does #1. It rarely does #2. It almost never does #3 or #4.

Foundation Question 7: What Would Make CX a Closed-Loop System?

For CX to be legitimate infrastructure (not theater), it would need:

A. Atomic Units of Misalignment

- Not "satisfaction is down"
- But "Promise X was broken in Context Y, causing Consequence Z"
- Specific, addressable, measurable

B. Routing Authority

- When misalignment is detected, the system routes it to the accountable owner
- Not as a "suggestion" but as a *triggered work item*

C. Closure Verification

- The system doesn't close until the misalignment is *proven* resolved
- Not "we think we fixed it" but "the signal changed"

D. Institutional Memory

- When the same misalignment recurs, the system knows
 - When a fix is proven, the system remembers
 - When a pattern emerges, the system surfaces it
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The Bedrock Question

Is there a legitimate, value-creating function in systematically closing the loop between customer perception and enterprise action?